OCHMO Office of Research Assurance (ORA)

Human Subject Research Protections Standard Operating Procedures (SOP)

SOP- 801: Post-Approval Support

Number	Effective Date	Version Number	Previous Versions
801	7/24/2024	v.1.1	v.1

Purpose

The purpose of NASA's ORA Quality Improvement and Outreach (QIO) Post-Approval Support (PAS) program is to support Principal Investigators (PI) and research teams in the conduct of ethical human subjects research throughout the lifecycle of the study. Through PAS service, QIO staff provide collegial support and regular informal check-ins with the research team. Working collaboratively with PI the QIO staff aims to proactively avoid potential compliance concerns.

Authority

Federal regulations [NASA 14 CFR 1230.109] afford the IRB authority to approve, require modifications, disapprove, suspend, or terminate human subjects research activities at NASA. The Post-Approval Support program is a service of the Chief Health and Medical Officer (OCHMO)'s Office of Research Assurance (ORA) Quality Improvement and Outreach program.

Post-Approval Support Services

Post-Approval Support (PAS) services are an opportunity for PI and research teams to receive one-on-one tailored education and resources to aid in the establishment and maintenance of study compliance following IRB approval. All studies under oversight of the NASA IRB are eligible to receive PAS services including research conducted at all NASA Centers, minimal risk and greater than minimal risk studies, and studies reviewed under exemption categories.

PAS may be PI initiated, conducted at the request of the ORA Director, or required by the IRB as a condition of approval. The IRB may also choose to require PAS for studies meeting an established criterion (e.g., first time NASA investigators).

PAS Process

The first step in the development of a PAS plan involves a brief (10-15min) virtual meeting with QIOstaff. During this meeting staff will work to understand support needs, research timelines, and availability. Following this consultation, QIO develops a set of anticipated services selected specifically for the study. Services will vary, but may include study start-up meeting, regulatory documentation requirements orientation, self-assessment, informal check-ins, compliance assessments, or other project specific options as appropriate.

Following the initial consultation, QIO staff provide the PI/research team with tailored service plan. The outlined services typically aim to begin shortly after IRB approval. Fluctuations in study timelines, research team needs, or changes in IRB approval status may necessitate revisions to the PAS plan.

Information Sharing and Follow-up

Report

Post-Approval Support is an informal service that does not trigger formal reporting. The IRB Committee may be informed generally (i.e., “a start-up visit for study X occurred”) but details are not reported. Should PAS uncover concerns significant in nature, a more formalized follow-up via Post-Approval Verification (PAV) will be initiated.

Significant Issues or Concerns

Issues uncovered during the verification process that ostensibly pose an imminent risk to the safety, welfare, and/or rights of research participants, or those that may constitute serious noncompliance are promptly brought to the attention of the ORA Director or IRB Chair to determine whether immediate action is warranted to protect participants or others.

Roles

IRB

The NASA IRB is an Agency-wide IRB operating within the Common Rule [NASA 14CFR1230] charged with oversight of research involving human subjects to ensure the ethical, safe, and equitable treatment of human subjects. The NASA IRB has the authority to approve, require modifications, disapprove, suspend, or terminate human subjects research activities. As part of the IRB’s role, the Common Rule explicitly grants IRBs the authority to observe, or have a third party observe, the research and consent process.

The IRB is administratively supported by the Office of Research Assurance (ORA), within the Office of the Chief Health and Medical Officer (OCHMO) Health Operations and Oversight Directorate.

Director, Office of Research Assurance (ORA)

The Director of Office of Research Assurance (ORA) provides support and management of the NASA IRB and HRMRB office (IRB Lead and IRB and HRMRB coordinators) and the ORA Quality Improvement and Outreach Lead.

ORA Quality Improvement and Outreach (QIO) Lead

The ORA Quality Improvement and Outreach Lead’s role is to provide support to the NASA research community through outreach, education, and the proactive identification of potential compliance concerns.

As part of the verification process, the QIO Lead seeks to confirm through observation and document comparison that research is performed in accordance with IRB approved protocols. The QIO Lead reviews study records, observes research activities, prepares reports, provides recommendations for maintaining research compliance, and assists with the development of plans for corrective and preventative actions as needed.

The Quality Improvement and Outreach Lead also develops and delivers guidance and educational programming to the NASA research community.

Principal Investigators and research teams

Principal Investigators (PI) and research teams hold the most critical role in ensuring that human subjects are protected, and that research adheres to regulatory requirements. PI and research team members are responsible for ensuring that human subjects research activities receive prior IRB review and approval, including any proposed modifications or revisions to previously approved research.

Acronyms

IRB – Institutional Review Board

OCHMO – Office of the Chief Health and Medical Officer

ORA – Office of Research Assurance

QIO –Quality Improvement and Outreach

PAS – Post-Approval Support

PAV – Post-Approval Verification

PI – Principal Investigator

QA/QI – Quality Assessment/Quality Improvement